Instructor Guide: Lesson 3 — Presentation Design Principles

Duration: 1 hour

Topic-by-Topic Teaching Notes

Structuring a Technical Presentation

Open with a short group exercise, not with the theory. Ask: "Have you sat through a technical presentation that felt like a data dump? What went wrong?" Give the room two minutes to call out patterns. You will hear, reliably: no framing, no clear ask, too many slides, slides that were really the analyst's notes, the recommendation never showed up. Write the list on the board. Every one of those is a structural failure, and using the class's own list as the agenda for this section earns more buy-in than presenting the problem → evidence → options → recommendation pattern in the abstract.

The teaching point to land is that "no structure" is always wrong, and that the four-part pattern is not the only right structure — it is the default. For an executive audience, the lead inverts (recommendation first). For a technical peer review, the forward order is right. Same four components; different lead. Students often want a single universal rule; the skill is reading the audience and choosing.

One subtle point worth naming explicitly: the slide-count discipline is a function of the time budget, not the amount of material. A five-minute briefing gets five to seven slides regardless of how much analysis sits behind it. The rest goes into an appendix or a handout. Drop this in early so the capstone briefing in Lesson 4 does not surprise anyone.

Slide Design Best Practices

The most effective way to teach hierarchy, typography, and contrast is a live before-and-after. Build two versions of the same OrbitCo finding slide on the projector — one cluttered (small type, low contrast, four unequal-size boxes, a logo eating the upper corner) and one clean (one chart, one sentence headline, ample margins). Hide your

screen for five seconds, show the cluttered slide for five seconds, then ask the class what the main point was. Repeat with the clean version. The contrast lands the lesson without any theory.

Follow up by asking which slide the author probably felt was "more professional." The answer is almost always the cluttered one, because cluttered slides look like "a lot of work." Naming that anti-instinct is one of the most useful moments in the lesson — you are teaching against the reflex, not against ignorance.

On typography specifically, call out the 18pt body minimum as a hard floor, not a guideline. If a student pushes back ("but my material will not fit"), the answer is "then make a second slide." The slide-count discipline and the type-size discipline are the same discipline viewed from two angles.

Using Layouts, Master Slides, and Themes

This is a live-demo section. Open an empty deck, switch to **View → Slide Master**, change the title font and add a small footer, close the master view, and insert three slides using different layouts. Show that the title font and footer are consistent across all three without any per-slide work. Then intentionally break one slide by changing its title font, and demonstrate the **Reset** button snapping it back. The demo is five minutes and saves the class from the most common intermediate-user mistake: "cleaning up" a deck by editing every slide individually.

If you have time, also show what a custom layout looks like — for example, a metrics-dashboard layout with four Key Performance Indicator (KPI) tiles in a 2×2 grid. This is the layout the OrbitCo Lesson 2 dashboard would live on if you were porting it to a recurring status deck, and it makes the case for the master as a reusable-documentation tool (the On-the-Job Learning (OJL) 5d point).

Creating Technical Diagrams

Live-demo two versions of a simple three-tier architecture diagram. First, build it from shapes and connectors in under three minutes — a row of three rectangles (Web, App, Database), connectors between them, labels on each. Use Align Top and Distribute Horizontally at the end. Second, build the same diagram using SmartArt's Basic Process template. Compare the two: the hand-built version is more specific and more precise; the SmartArt version is faster and adequate for a generic process-flow slide.

The teaching point is that neither is better universally — the choice depends on whether you need precision or speed. For OrbitCo, the escalation flow (L1 → L2 → L3 → Director) is a SmartArt job; the production network topology with specific service names is a hand-built job. Also flag the most common error in learner diagrams: unlabeled connectors. A diagram with arrows but no arrow-labels is guessable at best; a diagram with every connector named ("authenticates," "writes to," "polls") is unambiguous.

Embedding Excel Content in Slides

Demonstrate all three paste modes using the OrbitCo dashboard's weekly trend chart in view. Start with picture paste (edits to the Excel do nothing to the slide). Then embedded (double-click to edit; note the file-size jump). Then linked (edit the Excel, reopen the PowerPoint, watch the update). Close with the scenario question: "If you were sending this deck to your manager who will forward it to the board, which paste would you use?" The answer is picture — the board meeting will not have the Excel file. This one scenario makes the paste-mode choice memorable for the rest of the course.

If a student asks about OneDrive or SharePoint-hosted files specifically, acknowledge that cloud-hosted source files with accessible paths do work with linked paste, but warn that "accessible" means "accessible to every intended viewer, not just to you." A recipient without the right sharing permission sees a broken link. When in doubt, use picture paste.

Timing Suggestions

Segment	Time	Notes
Structuring a Technical Presentation	7 min	Open with the "data dump" group exercise; use the class's list as the section agenda
Slide Design Best Practices	7 min	Live before-and-after with the cluttered vs clean OrbitCo slide
Using Layouts, Master Slides, and Themes	5 min	Live-demo the Slide Master and the Reset button
Creating Technical Diagrams	5 min	Live-demo SmartArt vs hand-built on the three-tier diagram
Embedding Excel Content in Slides	5 min	Demo all three paste modes on the OrbitCo weekly trend chart
Activity: Slide Rebuild	20 min	15 min individual work + 5 min debrief
Activity: Build an OrbitCo System Diagram	15 min	12 min individual work + 3 min critique on the projector
Wrap-Up and Reflection	4 min	Key takeaways; one reflection question live
Transition buffer (included above)	-8 min	Demo blocks sum to 29 min, activities and wrap-up to 39 min — adjust by trimming embedding demo if behind schedule
Total	**60 min**	

Common Student Questions

Q: Does the problem → evidence → options → recommendation pattern apply to every technical presentation? A: No. It is the right default for decision-oriented briefings — the kind that end with a request. It is the wrong fit for urgent incident reviews (where the format is timeline + facts + open questions) and for recurring status meetings (where the container itself is the story). The skill is recognizing which kind of meeting you are walking into before you start building slides.

Q: Why 18pt body minimum? The room is usually small enough that 14pt reads fine. A: 18pt is the floor for a projector at the back of a typical conference room, but that is only part of the answer. The other part is that readers scan slides at a glance, and larger type forces you to choose the words that earn their place on the slide. A 14pt slide with 120 words is almost always a slide that should have been two slides or a slide plus a handout. The type-size rule enforces the structural-discipline rule.

Q: When I open someone else's deck and Reset does not fully clean it up, what is the next step? A: Reset only snaps slides back to their layout's master-defined positions. If the layout itself is misconfigured (custom fonts saved on the layout, wrong placeholder sizes), Reset cannot fix it — because those are the master's current values. Open the Slide Master, correct the layout, close the master, and Reset again. If a slide has been built outside any layout (typed directly on a blank slide), Reset has no layout to snap to — apply a layout first (Home → Layout → choose) and then Reset.

Q: Can SmartArt replace hand-built shapes entirely? It looks professional and it is fast. A: For generic flows (linear process, hierarchy, radial relationship), yes — use SmartArt. For anything where precision matters (a specific network topology with named services, a three-tier architecture with real dependencies, a state machine), SmartArt's rigidity becomes a liability. The diagram has to bend to SmartArt's template, not the other way around. Hand-built shapes take longer but draw what the system actually looks like.

Q: If I paste an Excel chart as linked and then both files move into a OneDrive folder, does the link update automatically? A: No. The link is stored as an absolute path at paste time. Moving the files, even together, breaks it. Fix it once under **File → Info →**

Edit Links to Files, then keep both files in the same shared location going forward. For a deck distributed outside the organization, use picture paste — there is no path that stays valid across recipients' machines.

Facilitation Tips

- **Start with the "data dump" group exercise, not with the pattern.** Letting the class name the structural failures they already recognize activates prior knowledge and makes the four-part pattern feel like a framework for what they knew, not a rule being imposed. If you open with the pattern, you are teaching against passive skepticism for the rest of the hour.
- **Protect demo time for the Slide Master.** The live master demo is the single highest-leverage five minutes in the lesson; it is what converts students from "formatting each slide by hand" to "setting it once on the master." If the structure section runs long, cut the standard-sections list, not the master demo.
- **Do not let a learner skip the Align-and-Distribute step during the diagram lab.** Unaligned shapes are the most common cosmetic flaw and the easiest to fix. Watch for it specifically during circulation — three shapes that are "close enough" are the signal that a learner has not found the Arrange menu yet.
- **Demo all three paste modes back-to-back on one chart.** Showing picture, embedded, and linked in sequence (with the same source chart) makes the comparison concrete. Verbal description alone does not stick — the class remembers seeing the file-size jump and the broken link.
- **Name the OJL competencies once, during the diagram section.** Say the words "the runbook visuals you produce in the field depend on the diagram skill you build here, which is why this lesson tags OJL 2d." The explicit connection from classroom skill to on-the-job competency is the point; students skim past it in a written tag but absorb it when an instructor says it.